When the MRBMs were first identified, it was quickly apparent that US early warning systems would not cover a threat from Cuba. The Ballistic Missile Early Warning System (BMEWS) was orientated to track Soviet ICBMs coming over the North Pole (as were the bulk of US air defence radars).[7] A Cuban Missile Early Warning System (CMEWS), code-named Falling Leaves, was hence improvised. A key element in the CMEWS was the space-tracking radar station at Moorestown in New Jersey.

On 28 October 1962 operators at Moorestown detected a ballistic missile launched from Cuba. North American Air Defence (NORAD) headquarters in Colorado were immediately notified that a missile was in flight and would impact near the city of Tampa shortly after 9.00am. The command post duty officers at NORAD immediately notified SAC headquarters. The President was not informed at this stage (or subsequently). NORAD soon learned that nuclear bomb detection equipment had not registered a nuclear explosion on US territory. A few minutes later, it was discovered that a test tape of a simulated missile launch had inadvertently been inserted into a machine at Moorestown. Was there a chance this could have triggered a full-retaliatory attack upon the Soviet Union, as President Kennedy had threatened on 22 October? Almost certainly not. It nevertheless illustrates the hazards of technology and the problems of warning intelligence.

Another man who saved the world

The incident bears some resemblance to one in 1983, when, at the height of the ‘Second Cold War’, Soviet satellite-based early warning systems detected the launch of five US ICBMs heading for the Soviet Union. The senior duty officer, Lieutenant-Colonel Stanislav Petrov, took the decision not to pass this information up the chain of command, where it would quickly reach the General-Secretary of the Soviet Communist Party, Yuri Andropov (who might or might not have been attached to a kidney dialysis machine at that moment).[8] Petrov correctly judged that there had been a system malfunction. He was trained to expect a US ICBM attack would comprise hundreds of missiles, rather than a handful. He subsequently earned the accolade of ‘the Man Who Saved the World’ (the title of a